Katherine Cooley, PhD

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Education

PhD, Mind-Body Medicine | Saybrook University, 2025

- Dissertation: A Heuristic Self-Search Inquiry into an Embodied Approach in the Experience of Eating Disorder Recovery.
- Committee: Clifford Smyth, PhD (Chair); Annette Anderson-Engler, PhD, MSW (Methodologist); Devorah Curtis, PhD (Reader).
- First-person qualitative inquiry using heuristic self-search inquiry, dialectical self-interviews, and reflexive writing. Developed the Self-Emergence Framework: emotional becoming, somatic becoming, bodily un-doing, and self-emergence.

MS, Integrative Medicine and Health Science (Mind-Body Medicine) | Saybrook University, 2016

- Thesis: Decreasing Stress to Increase Motivation for Wellbeing in the Workplace.

BA, English | University of New Hampshire, 1992

Research Interests

Somatic psychology and phenomenology of embodiment; disembodiment and self-alienation; first-person and heuristic qualitative inquiry; somatic resourcing and habitual patterns of perception; embodied eating disorder recovery; imagery, metaphor, and narrative; Taoist philosophy and embodied epistemologies; interdisciplinary somatic and mental health education.

Academic Appointments and Graduate Teaching

Adjunct Faculty | Saybrook University, College of Integrative Medicine and Health Sciences, 2020–present

- Teach master's and doctoral coursework: Imagery for Health; Mind-Body Therapies and Practices; Movement Modalities for Health; Evidence-Based Coaching; Intermediate Integrative Wellness Coaching; Advanced Integrative Wellness Coaching Practicum.
- Serve as dissertation committee methodologist, advising on research design, methodological coherence, analysis, and scholarly writing. Participate in curriculum development and faculty governance.

Faculty, Consciousness, Spirituality, and Integrative Health Program | Saybrook University, 2026–present

- Advise two doctoral students at the qualifying essay stage on art therapy with adult survivors of childhood sexual abuse and spiritual dimensions of trichotillomania.

Facilitator, Mind, Body, Spirit Integration Seminar | Saybrook University, 2021–present

- Lead required experiential groups of 6–30 graduate students; integrate reflection, imagery, mindfulness, creative practice, and embodied inquiry; coordinate faculty presentations.

Facilitator, Self-Care Workshop Series | Saybrook University, 2023

Adjunct Faculty | Gonzaga University, 2005–2009

- Designed a holistic yoga and wellbeing program with the Director of Program Activities and community studio partners.

Publications and Scholarly Work

Peer-reviewed article

Bentley, T. G. K., D'Andrea-Penna, G., Rakic, M., Arce, N., LaFaille, M., Berman, R., Cooley, K., & Sprimont, P. (2023). Breathing practices for stress and anxiety reduction: Conceptual framework of implementation guidelines based on a systematic review of the published literature. Brain Sciences, 13(11), 1612. https://doi.org/10.3390/brainsci13111612

Book

Cooley, K. S. (2026 [confirm publication year]). The Song in Our Bones. Self-published digital edition. https://www.songinourbones.com/ — Interdisciplinary inquiry into embodiment, phenomenology, somatic science, lived experience, and Taoist philosophy.

Dissertation

Cooley, K. S. (2025). A heuristic self-search inquiry into an embodied approach in the experience of eating disorder recovery [Doctoral dissertation, Saybrook University].

Manuscript in preparation

Cooley, K. S. Beyond co-researchers: Heuristic self-search inquiry and the contributions of Sandy Sela-Smith. In preparation for submission to Journal of Humanistic Psychology.

Selected Original Curricula and Educational Programs

The Practice Path — Curriculum Designer and Instructor | Joy Yoga Project, 2026

- Designed and taught an original 16-class somatic education curriculum integrating yoga, phenomenology, Taoist philosophy, existential inquiry, and embodied learning.
- Connected attention, meta-awareness, habitual perception, and embodied inquiry with movement, breath, postural practice, metaphor, journaling, and group dialogue.

Year of Mindfulness / Mindful Body | Spokane, 2015–2025

- Developed and facilitated year-long mindfulness and mind-body education programs; trained and supervised co-facilitators.

200-Hour Hatha Yoga Teacher Training — Head Teacher | Spokane Yoga School, 2006–2008

- Designed and taught curriculum in technique, anatomy and physiology, philosophy, pedagogy, and ethics.

Somatic Education and Practice

Somatic Yoga and Hanna Somatic Education | Eleanor Criswell, EdD, 2009–2015

- Personal mentorship and somatic study; Hanna Somatic Education Modules 1–3.

Katonah Yoga | Certified teacher, 2020- present

- Long-term study with founder Nevine Michaan and Abbie Galvin. Teach as a somatic resourcing practice informed by Taoist philosophy, yin-yang and five-element theory, movement, breath, geometry, imagery, and metaphor.

Yoga Alliance E-RYT 500 | 2006; over 25 years of teaching

Academic Service

Adjunct Faculty Representative, Faculty Senate | Saybrook University, 2026–2028

- Represent adjunct faculty in governance.

Curriculum and Program Development | Saybrook University, 2022-2024

- Participated in curriculum development and reaccreditation work for the Integrative Wellness Coaching program.

Professional and Community Leadership

Learner Experience and Equity Access Program Manager; COSP Facilitator | Circle of Security International, 2026–present

- Coordinate international online training cohorts of 40–135 learners; manage equity access program providing 300+ reduced-cost facilitator training seats across 36 countries; support implementation and impact measurement.

Founder and Teacher | Joy Yoga Project, Spokane, 2025–present

- Teach adult learners through somatic resourcing, integrating movement, breath, imagery, narrative, and spatial orientation.

Co-Founder and Co-Director | Movemore Spokane, 2003–2016

- Led community health organization on two-acre wellness campus serving 3,000+ participants annually; developed movement and mindfulness programs and conducted program evaluation.

Program Developer and Facilitator | Spokane, 2018–2023

- Somatic Grief Work Series (2022–2023); The Complete Back, informed by Hanna Somatic Education (2018).

Research Assistant | Health and Human Performance Foundation, 2022-2023

- Contributed to a systematic review of slow breathing interventions for stress and anxiety.

Consultant | SRC Consultancy / Spokane Regional Authority on Homelessness Initiative, 2020-2021

- Contributed to wellbeing and basic-needs assessment and feasibility report.

Certified Professional Guardian | Spokane, 2016-2024

- Served vulnerable adults under court-appointed guardianship.

Additional University Leadership

Head Women's Rowing Coach | University of New Hampshire, NCAA Division I, 1996–1998

Assistant Women's Rowing Coach | University of Virginia, NCAA Division I, 2001–2002

Professional Certifications

Circle of Security Parenting Facilitator (2026);

Associate Certified Coach, ICF (2024);

National Board-Certified Health and Wellness Coach (2023);

Lifestyle Medicine Coach, American College of Lifestyle Medicine (2022);

Health and Well-being Coach, Wellcoaches (2022);

Integrative Wellness Coach, Saybrook University (2016);

E-RYT 500, Yoga Alliance (2006).

Honors

University of New Hampshire Athletics Hall of Fame (2006); U.S. National Rowing Team (1993–1998): World Championship gold, women's four (1995); silver (1993, 1994); World Cup gold, Lucerne (1994); third place, U.S. Olympic Trials, women's pair (1996).